

Crucial Conversation Prep Worksheet

Scenario Example: Public displays of affection (PDA) or romantic relationships between peers within the team.



1. Lead with the Heart

Purpose: Approach this conversation with care, discretion, and professionalism. The goal is to maintain a comfortable and respectful environment for everyone while protecting the reputation of those involved.

Example Reflection: “I want to handle this with empathy and respect. I care about both individuals and the team’s comfort, and I want to reinforce professionalism without judgment or embarrassment.”

Prompts:

- How can I make sure the tone is caring and neutral?
- How can I protect the dignity of those involved while maintaining standards?
- How can I frame the conversation around team impact rather than personal behavior?

Example Opening Line: “I wanted to speak with you about something that’s sensitive but important. My intent is to make sure we maintain a positive, professional environment for everyone.”

2. Define the Ideal Outcome

Purpose: Visualize what success looks like after the conversation.

Example: “By the end of this discussion, I want both team members to understand that while personal relationships aren’t prohibited, public displays of affection can make others uncomfortable and distract from the professional atmosphere we’re all responsible for maintaining.”

3. Define the Negative Outcome to Avoid

Purpose: Identify what could go wrong if the situation isn’t addressed properly.

Example: “I want to avoid embarrassment or feelings of being singled out. I also want to avoid letting the issue go unaddressed, which could lead to gossip, tension, or a perception that unprofessional behavior is tolerated.”



4. Gather the Facts

Purpose: Ensure that your feedback is factual, not based on rumor or bias.

Example Notes:

- PDA observed during breaks or in the production area (e.g., hugging, hand-holding, extended close contact).
 - Team members have appeared visibly uncomfortable or distracted.
 - No prior discussions or warnings have been issued.
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5. Gain Buy-In After Presenting the Facts

Purpose: Allow peers to share their perspective and show understanding of the impact. This builds trust and cooperation instead of defensiveness.

Example Approach: “Now that I’ve shared what’s been noticed, I’d like to hear how you see it. My intent isn’t to judge — it’s to make sure we all understand how this might affect others on the team.”

Sample Questions to Ask:

- Do you understand how this could make others uncomfortable?
 - What are your thoughts on how we can keep things professional at work?
 - Would you be willing to be more mindful about how things appear to others?
 - Is there anything that could make this easier for you both to manage?
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6. Conversation Plan (Outline)

Example Flow and Dialogue:

1. Open with empathy and purpose

“I wanted to talk about something that may feel awkward, but it’s important for maintaining our team’s comfort and professionalism.”

2. Acknowledge their feelings

“I understand that relationships can naturally develop at work — that’s not unusual. I just want to ensure that what happens in the workplace remains professional and comfortable for everyone.”

3. Present the facts calmly

“There have been a few observations of physical affection between you two in shared workspaces, and a few team members have mentioned it makes them uncomfortable.”

4. Gain buy-in after presenting the facts

“Do you see how this might come across to others, even if the intent isn’t negative?”

5. Collaborate on the way forward

“Let’s agree to keep personal interactions appropriate for the workplace. That protects both of you and the comfort of everyone around.”

6. Reaffirm trust and partnership

“I appreciate your understanding and maturity in addressing this. I trust that you’ll handle it with discretion and professionalism moving forward.”

7. Reflection (After the Meeting)

- Did I approach the conversation respectfully and neutrally?
- Did I avoid language that sounded judgmental or personal?
- Did both individuals leave feeling respected and clear on expectations?
- Did I ensure confidentiality and privacy were maintained?
- What went well? What could I improve next time?
